

Resurrecting *Siege*: Collective Memory and Ideology Formation in the Iron March Neo-Fascist Network

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*This paper investigates the crystallization of ideology and culture on Iron March, a neo-fascist web forum active between 2011-2017. Building on literatures from social psychology, information science, and political science, I investigate how members participated in collective efforts to situate the forum in a legacy of past neo-fascist ideologues. I theorize that Iron March developed a cohesive and sustainable collective identity through its establishment of a “memory artifact” in the form of a forum-published edition of James Mason’s *Siege*. I use this case to argue that such efforts can help explain how such communities can contribute to offline mobilization despite no formal organizational hierarchy, a fluid and transient membership, and geographic dispersion. I argue that this collective memory was foundational to Iron March’s capacity to produce militant groups, offline violence, and political activism, and I theorize that this process helps explain online-to-offline mobilization in general.*

Word Count: 5740

INTRODUCTION

In 2015, the community on the Iron March web forum launched a “neo-fascist zine” called *Noose*. Featuring writing from Iron March members, the zine promoted revolutionary fascism via historical retrospectives, philosophical treatises, and guides for various tasks like cooking, orienteering, and prepping. Then, in 2017, a small set of leaders on Iron March resurrected a previously niche publication called *Siege*, written by an almost-forgotten neo-Nazi ideologue named James Mason. Repackaging *Siege* with new art, commentary, and a preface from Mason himself, the Iron March community gave *Siege* a new life, creating an entire culture around it and making it required reading for new recruits to Iron March-inspired offline groups.

These two initiatives were just two of many efforts by the Iron March network to construct a collective memory for the global neo-fascist movement. Events in the far past like the rise of Nazism, Mussolini’s Fascist march, and the Italian Years of Lead were characterized as pivotal moments in the

revolutionary fascist project. The development of contemporary neo-fascism, meanwhile, was given a set of heroes, a coherent philosophy, and a trajectory that culminated in decentralized revolutionary violence—the tactics and strategies embodied by Iron March and its offspring groups.

Iron March is one of an increasing number of cases of highly decentralized online communities having a foundational impact on the development of offline social movements, political activism, and political violence. Among far-right online spaces, it is one of the most influential: its members established resilient cross-national connections (Upchurch 2021), launched a still-surviving genealogy of militant groups active in the U.S., Canada, U.K., Europe, and Russia (Newhouse 2021), and served as a digital gathering-place of extremists who went on to commit arson, vandalism, and homicides (Singer-Emery and Bray III 2020). The aesthetics of Iron March's version of neo-fascism have far outlasted the website itself, serving as a loose connective tissue for extreme-right mobilization (Argentino et al. 2022). However, many other internet communities have influenced offline violence and mobilization, such as 4chan's Politically Incorrect image board, the "Terrorgram" network on Telegram, and involuntary celibate ("incel") networks.

In this paper, I contribute to the literature on political violence and extremism by theorizing that decentralized online communities can contribute to offline mobilization through the collaborative production of collective memory. Focusing on the Iron March case, I argue that such communities are capable of constructing collective identity and memory, despite no formal hierarchy, organizational structure, or even membership. I show how the Iron March administrators built the website to facilitate the institutionalization of neo-fascist memory, which is indicated by its structure and affordances. I then demonstrate how a shared narrative of the past was built through community-driven publication efforts, especially the republishing of James Mason's *Siege*. Finally, I conduct scaled analysis to describe the collective processes of ideology creation and memory formation in forum threads on the website.

BACKGROUND

Historically, the global far-right ecosystem has been organized around discrete groups like the Ku Klux Klan, but this has fundamentally changed. Concurrent with the rise of the Internet, far-right movements have increasingly embraced decentralization (Fürstenberg 2024; Newhouse 2021), stochastic

processes of mobilization (Conway et al. 2019; Amman and Meloy 2021), and "leaderless resistance" as proposed by Louis Beam (Beam 1992; Kaplan 1997). This radical transformation of the structure of far-right violence has made it difficult to accurately attribute violent attacks to broader organizations or movements, resulting in the acceleration of so-called "lone actor" attacks (Ravndal 2016).

However, as scholars have noted, these attackers are almost invariably anything but "lone": they are immersed in and conversant with amorphous, highly decentralized, "swarm" activity on extreme right-wing forums and online spaces (Törnberg and Törnberg 2024; Upchurch 2021; Kasimov 2023). This has heightened the need for systematic exploration of the social processes involved in the production of communities oriented around extreme-right political violence, especially those that organize online.

SOCIAL PROCESSES AND COLLECTIVE MEMORY

This paper builds on the study of collective memory, a concept explored in particular in social psychology and information science. While scholars have disagreed on a strict definition, the study of collective memory is generally credited to Halbwachs (1992), who conceived of a communal act of constructing a perspective on understanding the past. Distinct from a *history*, which is designed to accept complexity and multiple viewpoints in the understanding of the past, collective memory is the assertion of a shared viewpoint for a collective built around an opinionated infrastructure. In a review of collective memory studies, Wertsch (2018) describes the development of "schematic narrative templates" that allow for the entrenchment of collective memory in a society, culture, or group. These narrative templates can produce outcomes strong enough to induce "memory inertia," wherein certain collective memories become difficult to destabilize, even when confronted with evidence challenging their core premises (Schuman et al. 2005).

Collective memory processes play an important role in the development of social movements, allowing for the creation of group identity and the articulation of movement goals. Among many uses in political activism, collective memory can mobilize movement supporters to resistance via the recontextualization of certain historical narratives (Kuo and Jackson 2024). Collective memory has also been identified as a *necessary* element for continuous mobilization in movements. As argued in Lundström and Sartoretto (2022), for instance, collective memory "mediation" through different

types of media can produce differing outcomes, such as the production and re-production of memory frameworks. As a result of its importance, fringe movements have found ways to weaponize new technologies to manipulate collective memory of the past and push for the entrenchment of beneficial perspectives of certain events like the American Civil War (Wasilewski 2023). As Zamponi (2013) puts it, "Movements can challenge the hegemonic representation of their antecedents, as reported by the media, or distance themselves from them. A movement can adopt old symbols, traditionally far from its identity, and charge them with new meanings."

Scholars in the human-computer interaction (HCI) and broader information science traditions have applied the concept of collective memory to online communities by leveraging the availability of long-term digital trace data. Wikipedia has been identified as a hotspot of collective memory activity, as its structure is inherently designed to produce collaboration in the construction of perspectives of events.

Wikipedia visitors, for instance, exhibit patterns of behavior indicative of collective memory formation via the consumption of articles in the neighborhood of those about current events (García-Gavilanes et al. 2017). The availability of Wikipedia editing data provides a rich opportunity for quantitative analysis of collective memory creation, something that previously was rare. Jones and Keegan (2024) investigate the ways that Wikipedia editors diverge along language lines in their treatment of Arab Spring-related topics in Arabic or English.

Despite the revolution in research on collective memory powered by the adoption of the Internet as a core communication and mobilization medium, scant attention has been paid to the application of these social processes in the context of online extremist movements.

Several scholars have explored the development of an adjacent process, "collective learning" in "communities of practice", in the mobilization of extreme right-wing communities online. Kenney (2020) showed how an extreme Islamist network in Britain could be understood through the lens of collective learning, and Lee and Knott (2022) focuses on Fascist Forge—the short-lived successor to Iron March—to show how neo-Nazis engage in knowledge accumulation at the group level. Fürstenberg (2024) further builds the collective learning lens in the context of extremist groups, exploring how militant accelerationist extremists across 4chan, Iron March, Fascist Forge, and the "Terrorgram"

network on Telegram develop via a decentralized learning process.

IRON MARCH

Iron March was founded in 2011 by a Russian-Uzbek named Alexander Mukhitdinov (usually referred to by his online pseudonym "Alexander Slavros"), who had ties to the Russian military (Upchurch 2021; Newhouse 2021). Slavros launched the website as a replacement for the short-lived International Third Positionist Forum, his first foray into administering online neo-fascist networking.

Iron March was designed intentionally to be a sort of "digital campfire," a place where far-right extremists of many ideological persuasions could meet, collaborate, and discuss offline activities (Törnberg and Törnberg 2024). It was built in the tradition of other white supremacist and fascist "campfire" communities like Stormfront, but notably it aimed to be much more strategically coherent and consistent.

By the time it was taken down in late 2017, Iron March had helped coalesce a transnational, revolutionary neo-fascist movement that gave rise to a generation of street activists, training camps, and terrorist groups (Upchurch 2021). It produced its own textual and visual languages, unifying its movement under a common name, and influencing successors well into the 2020s (Colin 2024; Argentino et al. 2022).

A full snapshot of the website's database at the time of its demise was posted online by an antifascist activist in 2019 (Singer-Emery and Bray III 2020). This database includes near-comprehensive information on the website's members, their direct messages, the forum threads and posts, and logs and metadata on the website's structure. This database reveals that, despite primarily writing in English, Iron March users came from dozens of countries (Upchurch 2021; Singer-Emery and Bray III 2020; Ross and Bevensee 2019). All digital trace evidence presented in this paper comes from either this database or manual review of website snapshots stored by the Internet Archive's Wayback Machine.

STRUCTURE AND AFFORDANCES

The Iron March Charter and Logo

Iron March was launched in Fall 2011 with a small set of initial users and an overarching set of rules, called the "Charter". This Charter was composed of language primarily ported over from Iron March's predecessor, ITPF. While various friends of Slavros had contributed to it, its initial iterations were primarily the work of Slavros himself and his closest collaborator, Benjamin Raymond, an ex-British National Party activist and the future founder of the British neo-fascist collective National Action (Macklin 2018).

Applying the framework for institutional analysis developed by Elinor Ostrom and the Ostrom Workshop (Ostrom 1990; Ostrom and Ostrom 2004; Frey et al. 2019), we can understand the Charter as an attempt at establishing a "constitutional" layer of rules and norms for the functioning of the Iron March community. While all online communities have some set of rules to govern how users interact, much of the time these rules consist of low-level "operational" community guidelines and policies governing the set of allowable behaviors (Frey et al. 2019). Iron March is distinct in its early adoption of a constitution that established the processes by which operational and collective rules could be made. It also established a "vision" for Iron March, defining who the community would be for and, perhaps more importantly for a neo-fascist network, who it would *exclude*.

One mechanism by which the Charter asserted these rules is by initializing the Iron March community as an heir to a legacy of neo-fascist activism stretching back into the 20th century. Along with declaring operational guidelines, the Charter establishes the website mission: "Iron March is not a movement, but we expect users to share our purpose – to take an active interest in using the community, and when contributing to do so as fascists in ultimate pursuit of knowledge, ideas, contacts, etcetera," the earliest Charter from September 2011 states (Iron March 2011). It also positions the website in opposition to "white nationalist" communities: "This is not Stormfront. Our community is based on discussion and debate constructive towards fascist goals, it is not a hangout for White Nationalists and their unique subculture" (Iron March 2011). The Charter thus establishes Iron March as something more cohesive and directional than a "hangout" like Stormfront, but less unified than a

FIGURE 1. Flag of Iron March containing the "Machina Hierarchia" logo



social movement. Iron March aimed for creating a "forum, an information center, and a community for like-minded people."

The Charter positions the website in the legacy of past fascist and neo-fascist movements via the establishment of an aesthetic "brand". Alongside roles and rules, the Charter specifically declares the "Machina Hierarchia" as the website's logo and seal, and only administrators and moderators are allowed to include the seal in their profiles. While this logo (see Figure 1) is custom to Iron March, it is strongly inspired by historical fascist movements. The cogwheel in the middle of the logo, for instance, was originally used by the Deutsche Arbeitsfront, the labor organization ran by the Nazi Party following the Nazis' ascension to power in 1933 (Davis 2012). It has since been adopted by some neo-Nazi organizations, including the Hammerskins (Anti-Defamation League nd). The hands superimposed on top of the cogwheel likely make a variant of the triskelion, an ancient symbol that was used by certain Nazi divisions and has been extensively employed by neo-Nazi movements (Dyck 2016). The tree branches may have been taken from Nazi divisional flags. In addition to taking visual inspiration from the Nazi regime, the Charter also names the website's moderators an "Order of Knights" called the "Black Corps", both references to nicknames for members of the Schutzstaffel (SS) division of the Nazi regime ran by Heinrich Himmler.

These aesthetic decisions indicate an intentional cultivation of a shared "ancestry" for the Iron March project. Rather than use more "mainstream" fascist symbols such as the swastika or fasces, Iron March embraced the symbols of third positionist and esoteric movements. This suggests a narrowness of Iron March's collective vision of both the past and the future, which showed up later as Iron March users built offline groups (Upchurch 2021).

By the end of Iron March's existence, the website leadership had updated the Charter with a "Mission Statement" declaring the various strategic goals and tactics of Iron March. The mission statement establishes four main functions:

- Forging the 21st century fascist
- Fascist alma mater
- Fascist space
- Fascist fraternity

PUBLICATIONS

Resurrecting *Siege*

Prior to 2015, neo-Nazi ideologue James Mason had largely been ignored by far-right movements globally since the height of his writing productivity in the 1980s and 1990s. Mason's writings had not acquired much influence in shaping far-right mobilization and organization, and he was studied by social scientists more as a synthesizer of the far-right milieu than as a producer of ideology and movement politics himself (Johnson and Feldman 2023). In one of the few pre-2015 studies of *Siege*, for instance, Goodrick-Clarke (2001) argues that Mason should be understood as a reflection of the intersecting thought of Charles Manson, Ku Klux Klan leader Louis Beam, and other ideologues.

Mason was arrested and charged with sexual exploitation of a minor in 1993, which resulted in a plea deal and three years of incarceration. He was released in 1999, after which he lived on little income and government support (Sunshine 2024). Mason's writings were occasionally discussed in extreme right-wing circles during the 2000s and early 2010s, but offline action, including violence, was more frequently attributed to texts like *The Turner Diaries* by William Luther Pierce.

On June 3, 2015, however, Iron March user Zeiger started a forum thread in which he announced that he had edited and revised *Siege*. "I've re-edited the whole book to a clean and fresh look, with standard page size, corrected spelling and punctuation errors and clean formatting," Zeiger, a member of the Black Corps, wrote as an introduction to this project. "This is a huge step up from the garbage Solar-general edition,¹ and the paper copies go for 150\$ these days.... Every Ironmarch poster should read this book." Zeiger included a PDF version and later updated the forum thread with an EPUB version, to enable compatibility with as many devices as possible.

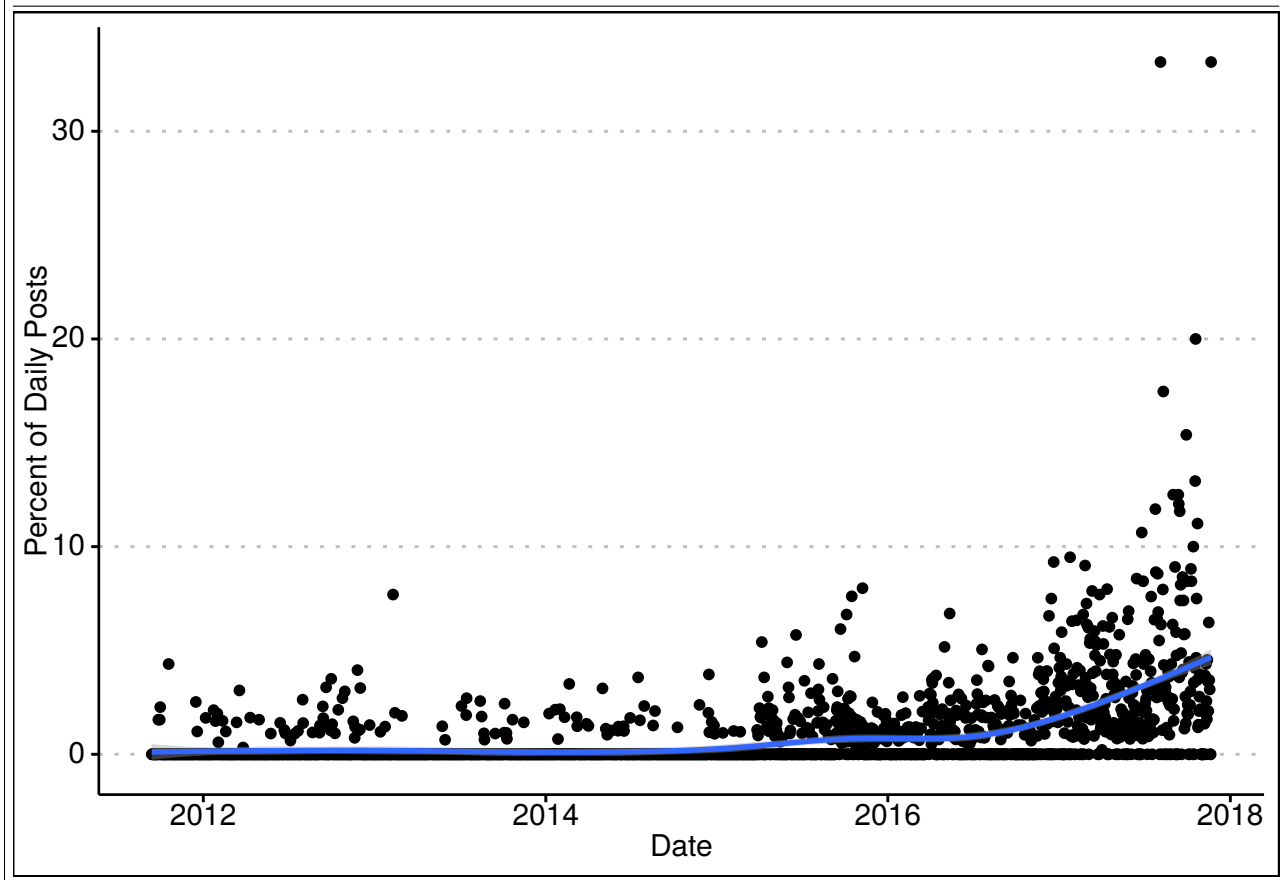
This newly updated edition of *Siege* is branded with a title page declaring, "An ironmarch.org publication", and its cover is a photograph from the Euromaidan protests in Ukraine in 2014. It includes a preface and introduction from the second edition (published in 2003); the introduction, written by Nazi publisher Ryan Schuster, asserts that Mason's writings are "so subsersive and violent" that other far-right extremists have been turned off of it (Mason 2015). This introduction aims to canonize Mason as a crucial figure in the legacy of neo-fascism, comparing him to Louis-Ferdinand Céline, whose antisemitic polemic *Les Beaux Draps* was banned in Vichy France for its criticisms of the French military (Maftai 2011).

Evidence suggests that right around this moment in 2015, the Iron March community began embracing *Siege* as required reading for aspiring neo-fascists. As shown in Figure 2, mentions of *Siege* in the forums increased significantly beginning in mid-2015 and accelerated through the end of Iron March's lifespan. This effort to canonize Mason as a near-prophetic figure in revolutionary neo-fascism gained particular momentum in 2017, when Zeiger's third edition was updated with a new preface from Mason himself:

Adolf Hitler, our greatest champion - as Rockwell would state - in two thousand years, declared in the course of his final radio broadcast to the German people - as well as to all the people of the White world - on January 30th, 1945, that with the victory of National Socialists over Bolshevism in Germany in 1933, the battle had been won and could not be reversed. Hard to believe then, hard to believe in 1967 or 1980. Maybe not so hard to believe today (Mason 2017).

¹This was one of the only versions of *Siege* available at the time.

FIGURE 2. Percent of forum posts on Iron March mentioning "Siege" over time, smoothed with lowess.



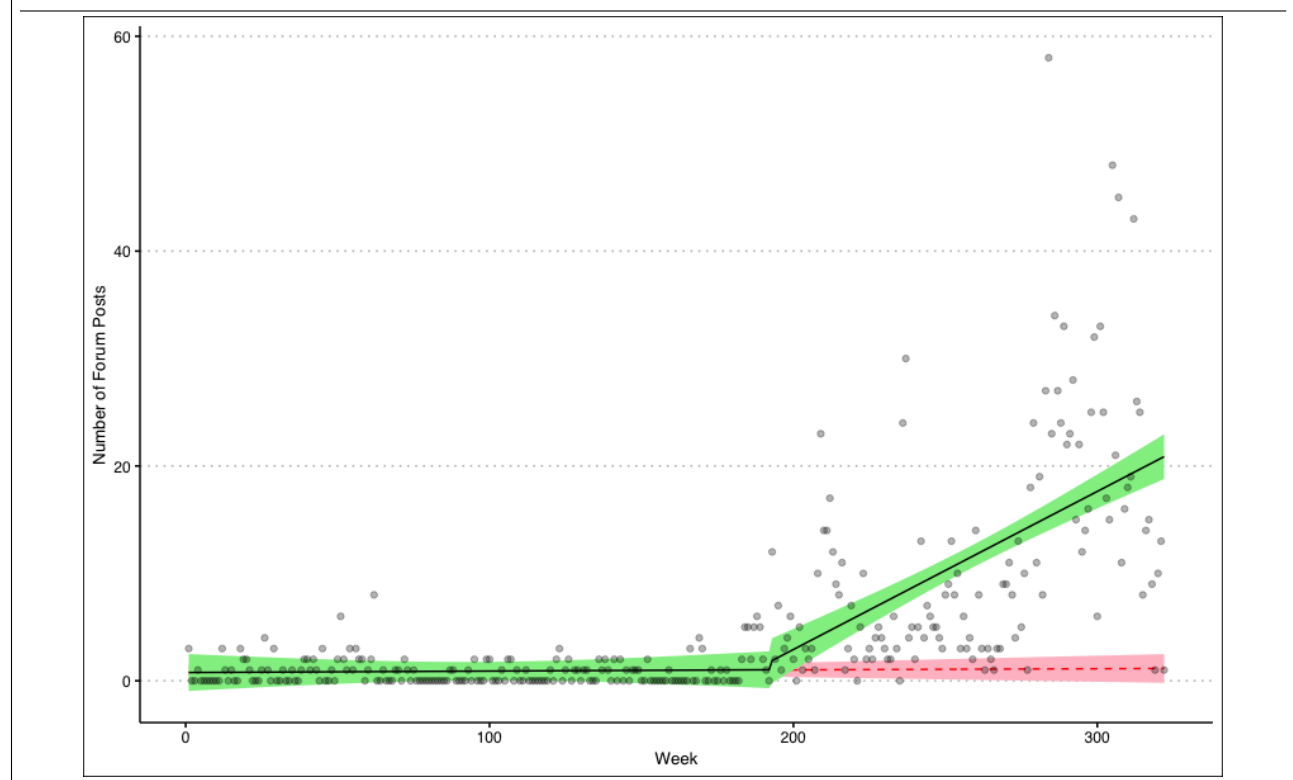
This new quote from Mason serves a dual purpose. First, Mason establishes a connection to a genealogy of revolutionary fascism stretching from himself to American Nazi Party leader George Lincoln Rockwell and originating with Adolf Hitler, "[white fascists'] greatest champion in two thousand years". Second, Mason suggests that the contemporary efforts in neo-fascist activism, specifically including Iron March, are the heirs of the Nazis who had won "the battle" for white power.

This resurrection effort had a profound impact on how the Iron March network mobilized in the ensuing years, extending beyond the scope of Iron March itself. Empirical evidence suggests that the publication of the Iron March edition of *Siege* was likely a turning point in the network's development. In Figure 3, I depict the results of an interrupted time-series analysis on the frequency of mentions of *Siege* in the Iron March forums. Using weekly data, I treat the publication of the third edition of the book by Zeiger as the "intervention", including both an intervention dummy variable and a running sum of weeks since intervention as independent variables. The green line depicts the predicted values from the intervention model and the red line depicts the counterfactual forecast of the book not being published. I find evidence that a clear, long-term increase in mentions of *Siege* can be at least partially attributed to the Iron March edition's publication, when compared to a counterfactual forecast.

Qualitatively, Iron March's projects increasingly used the "Siege" name and promoted their connections to Mason himself. In 2017, Iron March users launched an effort called "Siege Culture" which aimed to wrap a set of tactics and strategies in a unified aesthetic style. This involved the creation of two new affiliated websites—siegeculture.com and siegeculture.wordpress.com—the publication of numerous blog posts and essays, and a leveraging of memory artifacts for marketing and recruitment purposes.

For instance, Iron March users adopted the name and style of "Universal Order", a short-lived group formed in 1982 by Mason with explicit inspiration from Charles Manson. This name outlived Iron March itself and became used throughout the revolutionary neo-fascist ecosystem, including by militant groups with connections to the Iron March network. Atomwaffen Division (transnational, founded in the U.S.), Feuerkrieg Division (transnational, founded in Estonia), Sonnenkrieg (U.K., spinoff of National Action), and The Base (transnational, founded in the U.S.) all explicitly tied themselves to Universal Order and Siege Culture between 2018-2020, after Iron March had been closed (Newhouse

FIGURE 3. Interrupted Time-Series analysis of the impact of the Iron March version of *Siege* on mentions of the book in the forums



2021; Lee and Knott 2022).

Iron March users thus constructed a memory of James Mason and *Siege* as the bridge between the knights of past fascist movements and Iron March's efforts to build a contemporary neo-fascist "fraternity". Zeiger, Alexander Slavros, and the "Siegist" militant groups relied on this collective memory to mobilize. This effort provided a common narrative of both the past and the future that helped unify the geographically and ideologically disparate membership. The evidence presented in this section suggests that republishing *Siege* and bringing Mason into the fold helped set off the explosion of online and offline activity that characterized Iron March's later years.

COLLECTIVE MEMORY FORMATION IN THE FORUMS

The Iron March forums were called the "HQ" of the broader Iron March initiative, as they were where activists consistently returned from offline activity to interact, gather, and revise their tactics and strategies (Iron March 2017). These forums became the infrastructure for relationship-building,

FIGURE 4. Banner image from SiegeCulture.com in 2017.



ideological transformation, and sense-making for the neo-fascist community.

Users created over 7,100 forum threads in six years, and these threads were organized into roughly 120 categories. Threads were grouped into various subjects, including categories for offline initiatives (e.g. militant groups), logistics (e.g. administrator discussions and project planning), and interests (e.g. historical archives, ideological debate).

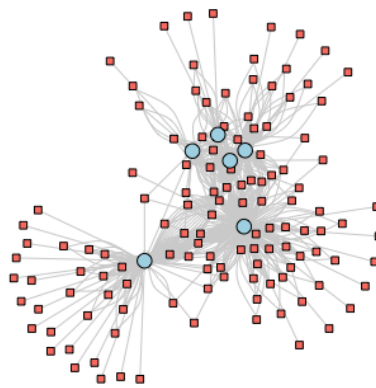
Many forum threads were dedicated to discussions of ongoing events important to the neo-fascist cause. These threads housed speculation, debate, and participatory efforts to make sense of international news. In this way, Iron March forum threads provided users a place to collaboratively (and sometimes contentiously) determine the "Iron March" way of remembering these events. They were mechanically similar to Wikipedia articles (Jones and Keegan 2024) or Facebook posts (Birkner and Donk 2020), in that a common narrative emerged from the collective set of interactions between users.

Memory Construction During Ukraine Conflict

In this section, I focus specifically on the case of the Euromaidan protests and subsequent Russian-supported separatist conflict in Ukraine that began in 2014. Iron March users created a series of five threads titled "Ukrainian Happenings," beginning in early 2014 and finally being closed in late 2016. These threads were organized around specific subjects: "Riots and Uprisings", "Crimean Separatism", "Right Sector", "Azov Battalion", and "General News". Summary statistics for the activity on these threads is shown in Table 1.

TABLE 1. Summary statistics on Ukraine conflict-related forum threads.

Thread Title	Original Poster	Start Date	Number of Comments	Number of Views
Ukrainian Happenings, Stage I: Riots and Uprising	Tabor4ok	2014-01-19	251	22062
Ukrainian Happenings, Stage II: Crimean separatism	Tabor4ok	2014-02-25	64	6193
Ukrainian Happenings, Stage III: Right Sector - The Post Happening	MoonmanKKK	2014-04-02	50	7620
Ukrainian Happenings, Stage IV: Azov Battalion	Alexander Slavros	2014-06-04	443	46096
Ukrainian Happenings, Stage V: General News	Alexander Slavros	2015-07-28	168	13743

FIGURE 5. "Ukrainian Happenings" thread networks. Red nodes are users, blue nodes are threads.

These threads evolved over time, engaging significant proportions of the Iron March user base. Of the 1,055 users who signed up for Iron March before 2017, 125 of them commented at least once on a "Ukrainian Happenings" thread. Administrators, moderators, and rank-and-file members took part; Slavros, unsurprisingly, posted the most frequently, followed by power-users like TheWeisseWolfe (Devon Arthurs, a co-founder of Atomwaffen Division (Upchurch 2021)), and Myrrysmies (who had connections to the Nordic Resistance Movement (Hayden 2019)).

As is visible in the network graph in Figure 5, there is a significant number of users who post across the different Ukrainian Happenings threads and thus likely represent some of the drivers of the memory formation around the Ukraine conflict. One way to quantitatively describe this structural characteristic is to measure centrality, in this case degree centrality, which describes how many different threads and users a particular node is connected to. Unsurprisingly, Slavros has the highest degree centrality, having

commented multiple times in every thread. Fellow original posters MoonmanKKK and Tabor4ok also commented on most of the Ukraine-related threads.

Another method of understanding the process of discussion in these threads is by identifying a post that is evocative of the overarching semantics and style across all of the threads. To do this, I combine all of the posts across the six Ukraine conflict-related threads into one dataset. I pre-process these posts to remove HTML tags, special characters, and extra white space. I then generate a document embedding for each post using Google's Gemini large language model, which produces a 764-dimensional vector for each post that retains information on semantic context, position, and spelling (Google 2024). After that, I produce a similarity matrix using cosine similarity, a measure that determines pairwise proximity for each pair of embeddings in my dataset. Finally, I calculate the mean similarity for each post to every other post in the dataset. The post with the maximum similarity can be interpreted as the most representative across all of the threads.

This process identifies a post written by Alexander Slavros on March 14, 2015. This post has multiple quotes from other users, which likely drove its high average cosine similarity score. However, it is also stylistically illustrative of the sense-making process of these threads: it engages in a passionate—often angry—argument with other users, and it asserts a strong opinion on the relevance of the Ukraine conflict to Iron March's goals. "Your basic position this whole time has been 'well I'd like to like Azov but I can't because they're not really fascists but even if they were SO WHAT'," Slavros writes in this post in debate with a user named Sturmgeist. "If you still don't get it, it's the SO WHAT attitude that I find appalling. As for your constant complaint about how they're not real nazis - I linked you to their materials that say exactly what they are, the core people who run Azov, the SNA people." Although highly entrenched in neo-fascist language, Slavros is clearly attempting to convince others in the thread that the Azov Movement is worth supporting because of Azov's links to transnational neo-fascism.

While these threads consistently hosted debate and disagreement, the Iron March network converged on support for Azov over time, likely due in part to these conversations. Eventually, an entire forum section was created to house discussion and collaboration about how best to support Azov. The construction of Azov as allies and comrades-in-arms survived past Iron March's demise and through the full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022. For example, the American Futurist website, which

was run by alums of Iron March and Atomwaffen Division, solicited writing from Azov activists in 2022 to call for the global neo-fascist network to support Azov in resisting Russia, and it still calls for donations via cryptocurrency for Azov fighters.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

Despite decentralization, fluid membership, and a resistance to operating as a movement itself, the Iron March website was a connection (and sometimes origin) point for some of the most influential neo-fascist militant groups of the past 20 years. It hosted activists from Ukraine's Azov Movement, Greece's Golden Dawn, Italy's CasaPound, the U.K.'s National Action, and Scandinavia's Nordic Resistance Movement. Its members also kickstarted the development of a "family tree" of new groups, including a set of "Siege Culture" terrorist groups starting with the Atomwaffen Division and a set of street activists starting with Vanguard America and the Rise Above Movement (Newhouse 2021). The ability for loose, non-hierarchical, decentralized "digital campfires" like Iron March to nonetheless provide support for overcoming collective action problems presents a puzzle important to the study of political violence: why does coordinated, motivated, and violent offline action emerge from some online spaces and not others?

In this paper, I theorize that this online-to-offline mobilization stemmed from Iron March's role as a nexus for collective memory construction. Building on the literature showing how collective memory is important to mobilization in social movement contexts, I treat Iron March as a community capable of achieving a shared narrative of the past. I present evidence that this collective memory informed the ways by which members mobilized for the pursuit of neo-fascist goals.

I focus on three methods by which the Iron March community built collective memory: the structure and rules of the website, the community's effort to resurrect James Mason and *Siege* and build a shared culture around it, and a series of forum posts created to discuss the conflict in Ukraine. I first argue that the Iron March Charter, the constitution by which the website was ran, included rules that "remembered" Iron March from its inception as an extension of revolutionary fascism in the far past. Through the aesthetics the Charter adopted and its establishment of in-group membership, Iron March rejected connection to other online extremist communities like Stormfront and positioned itself in line

with offline movements like the Nazis, Italian Fascists, and 20th century white separatists.

Second, I propose that Iron March's effort to resurrect and embrace James Mason as a movement hero helped build a coherent, influential narrative about the website's neo-fascist "ancestry". Through the publication of new editions of *Siege* and direct engagement with Mason himself, Iron March users created a shared conception of the website as the heir to the Mason-Manson "Universal Order" project, George Lincoln Rockwell and the American Nazi Party, and even Hitler, Himmler, and the Nazi regime. Iron March users created a series of memory artifacts to further assert the primacy of *Siege* to the collective memory of neo-fascist activism, including websites like SiegeCulture.com, an aesthetic style that became known as "Siegist" (Johnson and Feldman 2023), and the association of militant groups like Atomwaffen, Feuerkrieg, Sonnenkrieg, The Base, and others under the "Universal Order" banner.

Finally, I suggest that the Iron March forums provided an arena for collaboration on memory work. Focusing on a series of forum threads created about the Euromaidan protests and the separatist conflict in Ukraine, I show that both rank-and-file and leadership extensively engaged in meaning-making in these threads. I also introduce initial evidence that Iron March's embrace of Azov as an ally in the pursuit of global neo-fascist revolution was driven in part by the discussions and debates in these threads. This solidarity with Azov resulted in offline mobilization both during and after the Iron March era, including members of the Iron March network sending financial donations and even traveling overseas to fight in Ukraine (Rekawek 2022).

Explaining the transition from non-hierarchical, ephemeral online communities to coordinated offline political violence is an ongoing challenge in political violence. In this paper, I argue for increased attention on the dynamics of decentralized collective memory formation to help explain violent mobilization. While I focus on a single online community that was particularly associated with offline mobilization, this framework and theory can and should be extended to online communities in general. Future work should take a comparative approach to the study of decentralized collective memory formation. For instance, relative strengths of collective memory processes may help explain divergent outcomes when comparing Iron March and Terrorgram (high mobilization) to Stormfront and Gab (low mobilization). Online communities have increasingly influenced far-right political violence, and more scholarly attention to social processes may help explain why.

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